



2

Cognac has a lesser-known cousin—armagnac—produced in the Armagnac region of southwest France. While cognac is distilled twice, armagnac is distilled once. Since most of the cognac is exported—with the US and China being the biggest markets—it is more popular than armagnac that is consumed primarily in France.

So how should cognac be enjoyed? “While traditionally cognac was considered a digestif and was primarily had post meals, in the past decade or so it has become more of an aperitif,” says Magandeep Singh, a Delhi-based beverage consultant.

“Just like you can have a whisky before a meal, you can also have a cognac before a meal,” he adds. Singh says that even in cocktails, any cocktail made traditionally with a brown spirit, can be made with cognac. Of course, there are cognac-specific cocktails such as Sidecar—with orange liqueur, lime juice and cognac.

“If you are to mix a cognac with tonic or soda or use it in a cocktail, I suggest go with a V.S. It blends well,” advises Singh. However, if you are having an X.O or anything higher, Singh suggests having it on its own. “Those are so rare and such beautiful spirits that you should have it on its own rather than share attention with anything else,” he says. “It’s like if you had a Picasso or a [M.F.] Husain, you would hang it on the wall all by itself, giving it space, instead of crowding it with 20 less significant pictures,” Singh says, comparing the best of the cognac with high-end art.

With a slight nip in the air and the onset of winter in most parts of the country, maybe it is time to sip some cognac. **BT**

@smitabw



**1. Hennessy’s most coveted cognac is the limited edition Richard Hennessy. A decanter is priced for ₹5 lakh in Gurugram and ₹5.46 lakh in Mumbai**

**2. Martell, the oldest continually operational cognac brand, has a history stretching back to 1715**

**3. The exclusive Louis XIII, named after the 17th-century French king who was the first French monarch to recognise cognac as a category of brandy in its own right, is priced at ₹3.50 lakh in Delhi**

3